

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter One

The Architecture of Oppression

Before naming the systems that bind us, we need the grammar to name them with. This chapter builds the conceptual foundation — the goal of abolition, the requirements a system must meet to count as oppression, the four stages a matrix grows through, and the five domains through which any mature system operates.

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CHAPTER 1 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

The Architecture of Oppression

This chapter lays the foundation. It does not yet name a single oppressive system. Instead, it builds the conceptual scaffolding we will use in every later chapter — the goal we are working toward, the requirements something must meet to count as systemic oppression, and the five domains through which any mature system operates.

Think of it as the grammar of the framework. Later chapters will use this grammar to analyse specific matrices — Rankism, Cisheteropatriarchy, Enclosure, Retributivism, and the rest. Without this grammar, those chapters would be opinion. With it, they become diagnosis.

The framework is built on the Matrix of Domination proposed by the Black feminist sociologist Patricia Hill Collins. Collins argued that oppression is not a single axis (race OR gender OR class) but a matrix — multiple systems operating at once, each running through interpersonal, disciplinary, structural, and hegemonic domains. This chapter extends her model.

Two extensions matter most. First, the framework adds an intrapersonal domain — the inner beliefs and bodily harms a system produces once it has fully ascended. Second, it offers a strict definition of what counts as systemic oppression in the first place, so the word is not stretched to cover every form of discomfort.

READING NOTE

Every paragraph in this chapter is written to be tweetable. Each one carries a single self-contained idea, front-loaded so you can lift it without context. Where you see literal blank lines (____), the framework is asking you to write yourself into it — name a moment, a person, a place. The blanks are not decoration; they are the difference between reading about oppression and locating yourself inside it.

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SECTION 1

1. The Goal: Abolition Before Utopia

Utopias are not goals. They are sales pitches. Every utopia ever sold to a population has been used to install one oppressive system or another, dressed up as the answer to the last one. Heaven on earth always arrives with a warden.

The only goal worth striving for at this point in history is reaching what we will call **zero**. Zero is the point at which every oppressive system has been abolished and suppressed in perpetuity. Zero is not utopia. It is only the absence of the foolishness that has caused so much suffering.

Only after zero can we have a serious conversation about utopia. The people who will go from zero to utopia will need a world that is no longer running on oppressive infrastructure. They cannot build freedom on top of cages and call it freedom. They will need clean ground.

This means abolition is the eventual goal of the framework — not reform, not improvement, not a kinder version of the same arrangement. Ruth Wilson Gilmore, the abolitionist geographer, defines abolition as not just the absence of prisons but the presence of life-affirming institutions. Abolition creates. It does not merely remove.

Angela Davis extends this in *Are Prisons Obsolete?* (2003): an abolitionist vision does not ask how to make the cage more comfortable. It asks what kind of society would need the cage in the first place, and then it builds something else. The same logic applies to every matrix this framework will cover.

But before abolition, we must have understanding. You cannot dismantle a system you cannot name. You cannot name it if you do not know its parts. The rest of this chapter is about naming the parts — the requirements, the stages, and the domains — so that later chapters can do the diagnosis.

The Nigerian context matters here. The Federal Republic inherited colonial borders, colonial police, colonial courts, and a colonial bureaucracy. It then layered Pentecostal and Sharia revivals on top, followed by an oil economy and a military history. To abolitionists working in Nigeria, the task is thicker than in countries with fewer overlapping systems. Naming the parts is the first discipline.

***Fill in the blank.** The first time I realised that ‘the way things are’ is not inevitable was when _____ happened, and I noticed that _____ was treated as natural even though nobody could explain why.*

SECTION 2

2. Background: What Oppression Is Not

Before defining systemic oppression, the framework draws five boundaries. These are contrasts, not definitions. Their job is to stop the word ‘oppression’ from being stretched so wide that it loses its bite. Each contrast says: this thing exists, this thing matters, but it is not what we are studying.

2.1 Harm

Harm is broader than oppression. There are myriad ways to be hurt in existence as a living entity. A rock can fall on you. A disease can take your sight. A person you love can betray you. None of these are oppression. They are harm. The framework does not deny them. It simply studies something narrower.

Why does this distinction matter? Because even if every oppressive system on earth were dismantled, harm would still happen. People would still lie, cheat, steal, assault, and kill. The framework cannot promise a world without harm. It promises a world where the predictable, preventable, socially-organised harm has weakened or ceased.

This is why **Retributivism** is oppressive. Retributivism responds to harm with more harm. Nobody denies that rapists harm people, that paedophiles harm children, or that murder is devastating. The abolitionist position is not that these acts do not matter. It is that responding to harm with more harm produces a hostile society and an even larger pile of bodies.

The Nigerian evidence is heavy. The #EndSARS protests of October 2020 erupted because the Special Anti-Robbery Squad responded to accusations of theft and cyber-fraud with extrajudicial murder, torture, and extortion. The vast majority of those killed or jailed had not done what they were accused of. Retributivism did not produce safety. It produced Lekki toll gate.

Jungle justice — the public lynching of suspected thieves in markets from Aluu to Ori Oke — is the same logic in civilian clothes. Burning a person alive for stealing a phone is not justice. It is escalation. The framework says: attempt restoration and healing first. Only when restoration is resisted should coercive measure be used, and even then, never as spectacle.

2.2 Inequality

Inequality is not inherently oppressive. A person being smarter, richer, faster, taller, or more sexually attractive than another is not oppression. It is difference. The envious impulse to flatten every difference is itself a move toward Rankism, which we will study later as a fundamental matrix.

What is oppressive is **stratification** — a structured, zero-sum ranking that organises the whole society into above and below, winner and loser, and forces every new person into their rank at birth. Stratification is the residue that oppressive systems leave behind. Stratification is oppressive.

Inequality that is not stratification is not.

This distinction matters because oppressive systems can be built on inequality that is not itself oppressive. A group that invents superior military technology can use that superiority to invade a neighbour. The military edge is not the oppression. The decision to use it for oppressive ends — extraction, displacement, enslavement — is where the problem starts.

Militaries as they exist today are, of course, oppressive apparatuses in their own right. The ‘defence’ framing rarely survives contact with the budget. But that is a topic for the State Sovereignty chapter. Here, the point is narrower: do not confuse difference with stratification, and do not confuse either with oppression on its own.

2.3 Religion

Religion is not inherently oppressive. Despite what ex-Christian atheists in the West will tell you, religion is not the ultimate evil that must be cleansed from the world. Some of the most committed abolitionists in history have been religious — from the Quaker anti-slavery network to the Liberation Theology priests of Latin America to the imams who hid Tutsi neighbours during the Rwandan genocide.

But organised religion is, in practice, a willing amplifier and legitimacy supplier for oppressive systems. It does not extract or enforce on its own behalf consistently enough to count as a standalone matrix. Instead, it makes existing matrices harder to challenge by declaring their arrangements sacred.

This is why religion appears in the Canon of nearly every major system this framework covers. It backs Cisheteropatriarchy, Rankism, Retributivism, Colonialism, State Sovereignty, and Amatonormativity without a second thought. Not because religion is itself the oppressor, but because institutional religion has a structural interest in the stability of the existing order — and the existing order is built from these matrices.

In Nigeria this is visible in two registers. The Pentecostal prosperity gospel supplies Canon for Enclosure and Productivism by reframing wealth as a sign of divine favour and poverty as a spiritual failure. The implementation of Sharia in twelve northern states supplies Canon for Retributivism and Cisheteropatriarchy by anchoring amputation and stoning in divine law. Both are amplifications, not the source.

2.4 God, Gods, and Oppression

A thought experiment. Suppose the religion canon were literally true — that an almighty being or beings really existed and really had the power the texts describe. What would that world look like, based on how those texts describe the being?

It would look like the intersection of six fundamental matrices. Rankism: an entity that ranks above all others. Cisheteropatriarchy: gender roles enforced as sacred design. Statism: a claim to monopoly on legitimate violence and personhood. Enclosure: ownership of all land and resources. Retributivism:

eternal suffering for any offence, however slight. Adultism: humanity as eternal five-year-olds, incapable of moral choice without divine parental oversight.

Such an arrangement would not differ from this one in kind, only in magnitude. It would have the usual — lightning, plagues, brainwashing — instead of police batons, prisons, and television. The theologian Walter Wink called this the ‘Domination System’: a pattern that recurs across every sacred text and every secular empire. To rebel against it would be the same duty as rebelling against any tyrant.

This thought experiment is not an argument against belief. It is an argument that even a verifiably existing God would not automatically be owed obedience. The framework treats theocracy the same way it treats any other intersection of fundamental matrices — as something to study, name, and, if necessary, dismantle.

2.5 Lack of Imagination

A recurring failure in fiction is the inability to imagine a world without our oppressive systems. Power-fantasy webnovels, fantasy epics, space operas, even utopias — the authors keep writing the exact society we live in, with its full set of matrices intact. They rename the king, dress the patriarch in robes, swap the prison for a magical one. The structure does not change.

This is not a small problem. The cultural theorist Mark Fisher called it *Capitalist Realism* — the pervasive sense that capitalism is the only possible system, such that even imagining an alternative feels naïve. The same realism now applies to every ascended matrix. We can imagine the end of the world more easily than the end of the prison.

Here is an exercise for any author reading this. Write a standard story — any genre, any plot — with only one change. Exclude one oppressive system entirely from the history of that world. Write a romance without Cisheteropatriarchy. Write a family saga without Adultism. Write a war story without State Sovereignty. Not a politically correct version of our world — a world where that system was never invented.

Trust that the exercise would be good for the imagination. It would force the author to think past the residue. It would produce something worth reading. Nollywood, currently the world’s second-largest film industry by output, is largely built on Cisheteropatriarchy and Adultism as plot engines. Imagine what the next Nollywood would look like if even one matrix were absent from the writers’ room.

SECTION 3

3. The Three Requirements for Systemic Oppression

Not every uncomfortable arrangement counts as systemic oppression. The framework imposes three strict requirements. All three must be met. If any one is missing, the arrangement may still be harmful, unfair, or exploitative — but it is not what this framework studies, and the word ‘oppression’ should not be applied to it.

Requirement 1 — Tangible Extraction or Enforced Standard

The system must extract something tangible — material resources, labour, time, money, land, reproductive capacity, or anything else required for the subject’s current living conditions. Or it must enforce a standard whose non-compliance carries real-world consequences: loss of resources, physical harm, legal sanction, or exclusion from the institutions and spaces required for ordinary life.

The key word is **consequential**. If the only consequence of non-compliance is mild social awkwardness, it is not a matrix. If the consequence is that you lose your job, your freedom, your health, or your access to water, it qualifies. The system must remove options and alternatives in a manner consequential to the subject’s life conditions.

In Nigeria, NYSC extracts a year of labour from every graduate under thirty. Refusal carries legal sanction and locks you out of formal employment. That meets Requirement 1. A church’s dress code does not meet it unless non-compliance gets you thrown out of a network you depend on for housing or food.

Requirement 2 — Operation Through Three Domains

The system must operate through the interpersonal, disciplinary, and structural domains at minimum. In the framework’s vocabulary, this means it must be an **adult** or **mature** system. A single abusive elder in a compound is a nascent triad — serious, but not yet systemic. The same abuse codified into a network of compounds and then into national family law is mature, and qualifies.

The three domains will be defined precisely in Section 6. For now, the test is: does the system reproduce itself across generations of actors through networks and structural residue, or does it die with the original actors? If it dies with them, it is not yet systemic in the framework’s sense.

Requirement 3 — Acts on a Class Capable of Comprehension

Through the classification produced by the structural domain, the system must act on a class of subjects capable of comprehending both that something is being taken or enforced AND that an alternative is possible. This is the requirement that the subject class be capable of rebellion.

Animals and ecologies therefore do not count, in this framework, as subjects of oppression — not because their suffering does not matter, but because the framework’s analytical unit is the rebellion-capable subject. Teenagers and all other humans count. Children and babies count in a specific way: they share the ‘non-adult’ class with teenagers under Adultism, in the same way a fully paralysed person shares the ‘disabled’ class with someone who simply has a bad leg under Somatic Normativity.

This third requirement is why climate collapse is not, in this framework, a direct matrix of oppression against ecosystems. It is oppression against future humans (who meet the comprehension test) and against current humans whose land, water, and air are being extracted. The Niger Delta oil spills are oppression against the Ogoni and Ijaw. They are also ecocide. The framework handles the human side.

Fill in the blank. Name one arrangement in your daily life that meets all three requirements.

The arrangement is: _____. The thing it extracts or enforces is: _____. The three domains it operates through are: _____, _____, and _____.

SECTION 4

4. Three Key Definitions: Fundamental, Intersectional, Aggregation

Three terms will recur in every later chapter: **Fundamental Matrix**, **Intersectional Matrix**, and **Aggregation**. They describe three different ways matrices can relate to each other. Getting them straight now will save confusion later.

4.1 Fundamental Matrix

A Fundamental Matrix is a matrix that cannot be dissolved by dismantling any other matrix. It is either indecomposable — it simply exists independently — or it arose from another matrix whose origin is a concluded historical event that cannot be retroactively undone.

Rankism is indecomposable. You cannot end it by ending Cisheteropatriarchy or ending Enclosure. You have to dismantle Rankism itself, in its own domains. Coloniality is an example of the second kind. Coloniality arose from Invasion, but Invasion of Nigeria by Britain is a concluded historical event. You cannot retroactively un-invade. You can only dismantle Coloniality directly, in its current domains.

This matters because the framework's later chapters treat Fundamental Matrices as the load-bearing walls of the entire structure. Removing a non-fundamental matrix (an intersection or aggregation) while leaving its fundamental constituents intact does nothing — the constituents will regenerate the intersection in a modified form.

4.2 Difference Between Intersection and Aggregation

An **intersection** is a tight coupling. Every constituent matrix is necessary for the emergent phenomenon to exist. Remove any one constituent and the phenomenon dissolves, or changes into something qualitatively different. The constituents are not just co-occurring — they require each other to produce the emergent system.

An **aggregation** is a loose pile. The constituent matrices contribute independently. Each one adds its own layer without requiring the others. Remove one and the phenomenon diminishes but does not dissolve. It simply becomes less heavy.

Think of it as a recipe versus a pile of rocks. A cake is an intersection of flour, fat, sugar, eggs, and heat. Remove the heat and you do not have a flat cake — you have batter. A pile of rocks is an aggregation. Remove one rock and you have a smaller pile of rocks. Same thing, less of it.

The legal scholar Kimberlé Crenshaw coined the term *intersectionality* in 1989 to describe how Black women in US employment-discrimination law were failed by single-axis analysis (race OR gender).

The framework uses her term in this tight-coupling sense. Intersections cannot be addressed by tinkering with one axis at a time.

4.3 Intersectional Matrix

An Intersectional Matrix is a matrix that can be dissolved by dismantling all its constituent Fundamental Matrices **simultaneously**. The simultaneity is the hard part. If the constituents are not dismantled together, the remaining constituents will recreate the conditions for the dismantled ones to re-emerge, and the intersection will regenerate — often in a modified form that is harder to recognise and challenge.

Capitalism is the cleanest example. Capitalism is the intersection of Enclosure + Productivism + Rankism + State Sovereignty. Remove Enclosure alone (say, by nationalising land) and the other three will simply re-stratify access to the now-nationalised land through Rankism and State Sovereignty, with Productivism supplying the labour discipline. This is, roughly, the history of the Soviet Union.

The reason intersections regenerate is that each constituent supplies something the others need. Enclosure needs State Sovereignty to enforce property titles. State Sovereignty needs Productivism to fund itself through taxed labour. Productivism needs Enclosure to make labour dependent on wages. Remove one and the others reorganise around the gap.

This is why abolitionist strategy in the framework cannot be piecemeal. You do not ‘defund the police’ without also dismantling Retributivism, Enclosure (of public space), and State Sovereignty (which the police enforce). Defunding the police while leaving those three intact simply produces private militias, which are the same matrix in a different uniform.

SECTION 5

5. The Four Stages of a Matrix

Matrices are not born adult. They grow through four stages, each adding a domain. The stages are **Nascent**, **Fledgling**, **Mature/Adult**, and **Ascended**. Each stage is more reproductive than the last. A matrix at the Ascended stage is, in the framework’s vocabulary, the closest thing we have to an actual real-life god.

Stage	Domains Active	What It Looks Like
Nascent	Interpersonal only	A single triad (enforcer–subject–witness) with no network. The witness’s complicity makes it capable of reproduction, but it has not yet reproduced. There are probably billions of these running at any given moment.
Fledgling	Interpersonal + Disciplinary	The triads have linked into networks — communities (distributed) or hierarchies (nested stars). The system can now scale beyond the original actors. It is approaching its full potential.
Mature / Adult	Interpersonal + Disciplinary + Structural	The networks have left codified residue: rules, rankings, or categories that outlive the original groups. New groups form into the same pattern because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible.
Ascended / Realism	All four domains + stable Intrapersonal + Hegemonic	The system has achieved Realism. It is assumed to be the way reality works. It retroactively rewrites history. It claims there is no alternative. To challenge it is to challenge a hurricane.

Table 5.1 — The four stages of a matrix.

5.1 Nascent — The Single Triad

A Nascent matrix is a single interpersonal triad operating without network support. One enforcer, one subject, one witness. The witness is complicit — that complicity is what makes the triad capable of social reproduction. Without the witness, the act is just personal cruelty. With the witness, it is a system waiting to scale.

There are probably billions of these running around at any given moment. A landlord in Surulere who sexually harasses a tenant while the other tenants pretend not to hear. A lecturer in Nsukka who fails a student for refusing sexual advances, while the department looks away. A husband in Kano who beats his wife, while the compound calls it a private matter. Each is a nascent triad.

5.2 Fledgling — Linked Triads

A Fledgling matrix is what happens when nascent triads link into networks. The link can be hierarchical (an enforcer in one triad is the subject of a higher-level triad) or community-based (a witness in one triad becomes the enforcer in another, spreading the pattern laterally).

At this stage the system can scale beyond the original actors. A network of compounds enforcing the same standard against their daughters — through family associations, age-grade societies, or mosque committees — is a fledgling system. The #SexForGrades exposés by BBC Africa Eye showed fledgling Cisheteropatriarchy inside Nigerian universities: lecturers across departments covering for each other.

5.3 Mature — Codified Residue

A Mature (Adult) matrix has left codified residue. The networks have produced rules, rankings, or categories that survive the death and replacement of the original members. New actors form into the same pattern not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible.

Nigerian family law is a residue of this kind. The Marriage Act, the Matrimonial Causes Act, and the customary court system all encode Cisheteropatriarchal assumptions about who may marry whom, who owns marital property, and who gets custody. A judge in 2026 ruling on these matters does not need to be personally sexist — the bureaucracy enforces the pattern regardless of the judge's intentions.

5.4 Ascended — Realism

An Ascended matrix has achieved Realism. The term comes from Mark Fisher's *Capitalist Realism* (2009): the pervasive sense that the system is not one option among others but the very fabric of reality, such that imagining its end feels like imagining the end of the world. Fisher's example was capitalism. The framework generalises it to every ascended matrix.

An ascended matrix retroactively rewrites history. It claims there is no alternative. To challenge it feels like challenging a hurricane. All ascended matrices produce a stable intrapersonal domain (the inner beliefs of enforcers, subjects, and witnesses) and have a hegemonic domain (the Ascension Ritual that maintains Realism). These will be defined in Section 6.

At this stage, the matrix is the closest thing we have to an actual real-life god. It has the power to rewrite history, morality, perception, and reality. State Sovereignty is ascended in Nigeria — most citizens cannot imagine a society without the state's monopoly on violence, despite the fact that the state's monopoly is barely a few centuries old as a global norm.

SECTION 6

6. The Five Domains of Domination

Patricia Hill Collins described the Matrix of Domination as operating across multiple domains: interpersonal, disciplinary, structural, and hegemonic. The framework extends her model into **five** domains. The first four are Collins's. The fifth — the intrapersonal domain — is added here because Collins's hegemonic domain conflates two different things: the ritual that produces Realism, and the inner beliefs and bodily harms Realism produces. The framework separates them.

Each domain is presented below in the order a matrix develops them. A matrix acquires interpersonal first, then disciplinary, then structural, then (if it ascends) hegemonic and intrapersonal. Reading the domains in this order is reading the life-cycle of a matrix from birth to godhood.

6.1 The Interpersonal Domain

The Interpersonal Domain is the smallest reproductive unit of any matrix. It is refined into a set of **interpersonal triads** — three-role structures, each enforcing one standard or extracting one tangible thing. A matrix may have only enforcement triads, only extraction triads, or both. When you take all the enforcement triads and extraction triads together, you get the Interpersonal Domain.

The Triad and Its Roles

A triad has three core roles, each of which may be occupied by one or many individuals. The roles are defined by what the person or group **does**, not by who they are. A parent, an employer, a peer, a stranger, a community, or an institution's representative can fill any role.

Enforcer / Extractor / Validator. The person or group who enforces a standard, extracts a tangible thing, or validates the enforcement or extraction of another. Validation is the line between this role and the witness. If you validate the act, you occupy this role — whether or not you were physically present or personally benefited.

Subject. The person or group on whom the standard is enforced or from whom the tangible thing is extracted. They may conform or rebel. Their position as subject is defined by being the one acted upon.

Witness. The person or group who knows of the act — through direct perception, mediated transmission (video, gossip, testimony), or subsequent hearing — does not participate, does not validate it, and either dissents (breaking the triad) or is complicit (enabling reproduction through inaction). The witness is not a personal beneficiary of the specific enforcement or extraction.

The Non-Extracting Beneficiary

A special role appears in extraction contexts. The **Non-Extracting Beneficiary** receives material benefit from a specific extraction, is not the active extractor, does not validate the extraction (or they

would become an enforcer), and does not dissent from it (or they would become a dissenting witness). They cannot be a witness because the framework correctly excludes personal beneficiaries from the witness role.

Example: the son in a household who benefits from the unpaid domestic labour of his mother, who is being extracted from by the heads of the household. The son is not personally extracting her labour. He is not validating the extraction (if he were, he would be an enforcer). He is not dissenting (if he were, he would be a dissenting witness). He is receiving material benefit. He is a Non-Extracting Beneficiary.

This role is unstable. The moment the son makes any attempt to validate or extract, he instantly becomes an extractor too, and remains that way as long as the triad persists. Most Non-Extracting Beneficiaries live one excuse away from becoming extractors. The role describes a position, not a permanent identity.

Seven Key Properties of the Triad

- **1. The witness is the line between personal cruelty and social reproduction.** Without a witness, the act is harm. With a witness, it becomes a system. The neighbour who says nothing is a complicit witness. The neighbour who says ‘she deserved it’ is now an enforcer.
- **2. The triad does not require every role present physically.** It can be assembled synchronously (all roles in one room) or asynchronously (roles filled across days, years, or media platforms through testimony, gossip, memory, or algorithmic circulation). A Twitter quote-tweet of a harassment allegation can complete an asynchronous triad.
- **3. These are roles, not persons.** One individual may occupy multiple roles across different triads, and a single role may be filled by many individuals. A triad might have 30 enforcers, 10 subjects, and 12 witnesses.
- **4. A single triad does one or the other — enforcement or extraction.** If both seem to be occurring simultaneously, they are two triads running in parallel on the same subject, not one triad doing two things. This rule keeps later analysis clean.
- **5. Roles must be filled by living persons or groups.** If a rule that dead people made is being enforced, that is bureaucracy (a structural residue), not an interpersonal triad. A film, book, or cultural text that shapes current behaviour is not an enforcer — it is structural residue or Canon. The enforcer in any triad is the living person who performs the enforcement now.
- **6. Extraction triads transfer something tangible.** Labour, money, land, time, physical resources, or reproductive capacity must pass from subject to extractor. If nothing tangible passes, it is an enforcement triad. Not every matrix needs an extraction triad.
- **7. The witness cannot participate in enforcement, extraction, or validation.** The moment they do, they become an enforcer / extractor / validator. The roles are mutually exclusive at any given moment, even if a person moves between them over time.

Nigerian example: a senior civil servant in Abuja demands a bribe from a job applicant (extractor). The applicant pays (subject). The receptionist watches and says nothing (complicit witness). The applicant’s uncle, who helped her prepare for the interview and who will share in the salary if she gets

the job but who does not know about the bribe, is not a witness — he is a potential Non-Extracting Beneficiary once the extraction is revealed to him and he does not dissent.

6.2 The Disciplinary Domain

The Disciplinary Domain is what happens when interpersonal triads link into networks. The triad is the node. Either the enforcer or the witness is the link between triad-nodes. Networks take two forms, both adapted from the sociologist Michel Foucault's work on discipline: **hierarchies** and **communities**.

Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars

A Disciplinary Hierarchy is a network of stars. The enforcer of one triad-node is also the subject of a higher-level triad-node, creating a chain of nested enforcement. Every middle position is simultaneously subject to the level above and enforcer to the level below.

The Nigerian Police Force is a textbook hierarchy. An Inspector-General enforces standards on Commissioners, who enforce on Area Commanders, who enforce on Divisional Officers, who enforce on Sergeants, who enforce on Constables — who, at the bottom, enforce on the public. Each layer is subject above and enforcer below. The SARS officer who extorted a young man at a checkpoint was himself being extorted by his superiors through quota systems.

Hierarchies scale by adding layers. They reproduce by promotion: today's subject is being groomed to be tomorrow's enforcer. The hierarchy teaches its subjects to want the position above them, which means learning to enforce the standard on those below. This is how Rankism recruits.

Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network

A Disciplinary Community is a distributed network. The witness of one triad-node becomes the enforcer, subject, or witness of another triad-node. The pattern spreads laterally through any person who has witnessed the enforcement or extraction without dissenting. There is no peak. There is no chain of command. There is only circulation.

Gossip is the simplest mechanism of disciplinary community. A compound in Enugu witnesses a beating next door and does not intervene. The next week, the same compound beats one of its own. The pattern has jumped across household boundaries through silent witnessing. Religion amplifies this: sermons, testimonies, and church discipline meetings circulate enforcement patterns across thousands of households without any central command.

The #EndSARS movement was, briefly, a counter-community — witnesses ceasing to be complicit and becoming dissenting. The state's response (the Lekki toll gate shooting of 20 October 2020) was a hierarchy reasserting itself through fast death against the dissenting witnesses. The framework treats both moves as analytically legible: one was a community breaking a triad, the other was a hierarchy restoring one.

6.3 The Structural Domain

The Structural Domain is what survives the **Ship of Theseus test**. When the people in the initial triad are dead and replaced, when the networks are disbanded and reform, what is consistent? What outlives both individuals and groups? What remains that forces new individuals and groups to re-form into the same patterns — not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible?

The framework identifies three residues: **Bureaucracy**, **Stratification**, and **Classification**. These are not mapped one-to-one from the disciplinary forms. A matrix may produce one, two, or all three. Some leave Classification only. Some leave Bureaucracy and Classification. Some leave Stratification and Classification. What matters is that each residue continues to impose compulsory performance on new actors.

Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures

Bureaucracy is the residue of rules and procedures. It forces new individuals into triad roles through compulsory interaction with formal institutions. You do not need to be personally sexist to enforce sexism if the form you are processing has a ‘wife’s signature’ field and no ‘husband’s signature’ field. The bureaucracy does the enforcement.

NYSC is a clean Nigerian example. The National Youth Service Corps was created in 1973 to integrate the country after the civil war. Fifty years later, the original decree has become a bureaucracy that forces every graduate under thirty to relocate, wear a uniform, and perform labour — or face exclusion from the formal labour market. The people who wrote the decree are mostly dead. The bureaucracy lives.

Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings

Stratification is the residue of zero-sum rankings — written or unwritten, above/below or winner/loser. It forces new individuals into triad roles through the daily experience of the rank in every hierarchical encounter. You learn your rank by being ranked, and you enforce it on those below you because the ranking system punishes you if you do not.

The Nigerian seniority system — in families, in offices, in the military, in churches — is stratification. A 25-year-old engineer in a Lagos firm does not need to be told to defer to a 50-year-old colleague. The ranking is in the air. Challenging it carries real costs: lost promotions, social ostracism, even dismissal. Stratification makes the rank compulsory without anyone having to issue an order.

Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions

Classification is the residue of categorical divisions — written or unwritten, in/out or us/them. It forces new individuals into triad roles through answering to a class name in every social and administrative interaction. You carry the class name on your ID card, in your accent, in your name, in your skin. The classification does the work before any individual enforcer shows up.

Ethnic classification in Nigeria is the obvious case. The ‘state of origin’ field on every form, the ‘federal character’ principle in hiring, the informal ethnic quotas in universities and banks — all of these are classification residue. A Yoruba person applying for a job in Kano, or an Igbo person

applying in Ibadan, is acted on by the classification before the interview begins.

Classification is the most universal residue. Almost every matrix produces it. Bureaucracy and Stratification are more selective. The framework's later chapters will note, for each matrix, which residues it leaves behind.

6.4 The Hegemonic Domain — The Ascension Ritual

The Hegemonic Domain appears only when a matrix is ascending to Realism. The domain is the Ascension Ritual — the process by which a mature system converts its structural residues, disciplinary networks, and interpersonal triads into a stable Intrapersonal Domain. The Ritual operates through two simultaneous mechanisms: **Canon** and **Practice**.

Canon — Rewriting History

Canon is the present belief that things have always been so. When structural residues — Bureaucracy, Stratification, Classification — persist long enough, their origination is forgotten. They are assumed to have always existed rather than being a temporary arrangement. Canon is not the history of how the residues were built. Canon is the present forgetting of that history.

Canon is the layer where organised religion typically plugs in. Religion supplies the 'sacred' framing that converts a bureaucratic arrangement into an eternal one. The Pentecostal prosperity gospel supplies Canon for Enclosure and Productivism by reframing wealth as divine favour. Sharia implementation in northern Nigeria supplies Canon for Retributivism by anchoring amputation in divine law. Religion does not extract or enforce on its own. It canonises.

Canon produces three internalised states, which the Intrapersonal Domain formalises: **Internalised Authority** (the felt right to enforce, regardless of personal gain), **Internalised Domination** (only when stratification is produced — the felt entitlement to receive extraction from those below), and **Internalised Oppression** (the beliefs and obligations that prevent the subject from rebelling and the witness from dissenting).

Practice — Rewriting Reality

Practice is the second mechanism of the Ascension Ritual. The interpersonal triad is repeated, again and again, until it becomes habit for the participants. The enforcer forgets they can choose not to enforce. The extractor forgets they can choose not to extract. The validator forgets they can choose not to validate. The subject forgets they can rebel. The witness forgets they can dissent.

Practice is the mechanism Pierre Bourdieu called *habitus* — the sediment of repeated practice in the body, such that the social order no longer needs conscious compliance because it has become the body's default. The Nigerian child who learns to kneel when greeting elders is undergoing Practice for Rankism. The wife who learns to serve her husband's plate first is undergoing Practice for Cisheteropatriarchy. None of this requires belief. It only requires repetition.

If a system successfully rewrites history (Canon) and rewrites reality (Practice), it has ascended. It has achieved Realism. It has produced a stable Intrapersonal Domain. At that point, the system is no

longer experienced as a system. It is experienced as the way things are.

6.5 The Intrapersonal Domain

The Intrapersonal Domain is produced after a successful Ascension Ritual. It is the inner world the matrix builds inside its participants — the felt rights, entitlements, beliefs, and bodily harms that the system generates once it has become Realism. The domain has four components: Internalised Authority, Internalised Domination, Internalised Oppression, and Death.

Internalised Authority — All Ascended Systems

Internalised Authority is the set of felt rights (and sometimes obligations) that a matrix teaches its enforcers and validators to expect as natural, automatic, or unquestionable. Specifically: the right to enforce the system's standard on others, regardless of personal material gain. Even without stratification, the enforcer feels their enforcement is legitimate, appropriate, and normal.

The Nigerian parent who beats their adult daughter for staying out late, even though the parent gains nothing materially from the beating, is operating from Internalised Authority. The beating does not extract labour. It does not transfer resources. It enforces a standard — 'daughters obey' — that the parent has been taught they have a right to enforce. The right feels natural. That is the tell.

Internalised Domination — Only With Stratification

Internalised Domination is the set of entitlements that a matrix teaches its extractors to expect as natural, automatic, or unquestionable. Specifically: the right to receive material extraction from those ranked below them. This component appears **only** in ascended systems that produce Stratification as a structural residue. A system that has ascended without producing stratification does not have Internalised Domination — and the framework does not explain its absence, it simply omits it.

Rankism produces Internalised Domination. The senior civil servant who expects 'appreciation' (a bribe) from every junior applicant has internalised the entitlement to receive extraction from those below. Amatonormativity, which is ascended but does not produce stratification, does not produce Internalised Domination. It produces Internalised Authority (the right to enforce couple-norms on singles) and Internalised Oppression (the beliefs singles absorb about their incompleteness) but not Domination.

Internalised Oppression — Subjects and Witnesses

Internalised Oppression is the set of beliefs and obligations that a matrix teaches its subjects and witnesses to prevent the rebellion of the subject and the dissent of the witness. It is the inner mechanism that keeps the interpersonal triad intact from the inside. The subject is taught that rebellion is impossible, immoral, or pointless. The witness is taught that dissent is dangerous, divisive, or unproductive.

Frantz Fanon described this in *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952): the colonised subject internalises the coloniser's frame so deeply that they experience their own liberation as a kind of death. The Nigerian undergraduate who has been sexually harassed by a lecturer but does not report because 'nothing will

happen’ and ‘it will ruin my career’ is exhibiting Internalised Oppression. The classmates who know and say nothing are exhibiting the witness-side of the same mechanism.

Death — Fast and Slow

Death is the list of ways a system can cause premature destruction of a person’s body, life, or way of being. Sometimes the death is fast: bombing, lynching, police murder, the Lekki toll gate shooting, the Aluu four, the Boko Haram massacres in Baga and Bama. Fast death is spectacular. It makes the news.

Sometimes the death is slow: chronic illness from stress, grinding attrition, environmental poisoning, the erasure of a language or culture. The Ogoni fisherman whose creek has been oiled for forty years is undergoing slow death. The market woman in Onitsha who has not slept more than five hours in two decades is undergoing slow death. The graduate who has been unemployed for seven years and now believes he is worthless is undergoing slow death. None of these make the news. They are the matrix’s quiet tax.

Theorist Ruth Wilson Gilmore defines racism — and, by extension, any oppressive system — as ‘the state-sanctioned or extralegal production and exploitation of group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death.’ The framework adopts her definition of Death as the floor of the Intrapersonal Domain. Every ascended matrix kills some of its subjects earlier than they would otherwise die. The matrix that does not kill is not yet ascended.

Achille Mbembe’s concept of *necropolitics* (2003) extends this: the ultimate expression of sovereignty is the power to dictate who may live and who must die, and in what conditions. The framework treats Death (fast and slow) as the terminus of every ascended matrix’s Intrapersonal Domain. When later chapters list Death for each matrix, they are listing the specific ways that matrix shortens lives.

Fill in the blank. Looking at the five domains, which matrix feels most personally present in your life right now? The matrix is _____. The interpersonal triad I am most often in is (enforcer / subject / witness / non-extracting beneficiary): _____. The form of Death (fast or slow) I am most afraid of from this matrix is: _____.

SECTION 7

7. Endnotes & References

References cited inline in this chapter, in APA format. The list is not exhaustive of the literature on any single concept — it is the set of sources the framework is directly borrowing from in this installment. Later chapters will append their own references.

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Further Reading

Chapter 2 will open the catalogue of Fundamental Matrices with Rankism (Archism, Rank, and Tenurism). Each subsequent chapter takes one matrix and runs it through the five domains defined here. If this chapter felt abstract, the next will feel concrete — every domain will be filled with a specific system's specific enforcement, extraction, residue, canon, and death.

If you are reading this chapter as a stand-alone document, the rest of the framework is in production. The order is Fundamental Matrices first, then Intersectional Matrices, then Aggregations, then Other Topics of Note. The framework is designed to be read in order, but each chapter can be read alone once this one is internalised.